PART 9 OF 11 · LAYER 4: CLEAN TO REMOVE ALLERGENS

# A cleaning routine that removes allergens

**THE SIMPLE VERSION**

**We want to pick dust up, not push it into the air.**
**Use a wet cloth, not a dry duster.**
**Clean from the top down, and do the floor last.**

How you clean matters as much as how often. Large allergen particles settle quickly, while finer dust stirred up by cleaning can take more than two hours to settle.[1,2] The aim is to capture and remove dust, not move it around.

- **Use a sealed HEPA vacuum**, or a central vacuum that vents outside, so fine allergen stays in the machine.[3] Empty canisters or change bags outdoors.
- **The sensitive person should not be the one vacuuming**, because exposure goes up during vacuuming and emptying.[3] Clean when they are away, avoid cleaning their bedroom at night, and anyone allergic who must clean should wear an N95 mask.[2]
- **Damp-dust, don't dry-dust.** Wipe hard surfaces with a damp cloth and damp-mop floors rather than sweeping.[4]
- **Work top to bottom**: ceiling fan blades, vents and grilles, shelves, furniture, then floors last.
- **Leave shoes at the door** and use entry mats to cut down tracked-in dust and pollen.[5]
- **Hidden damp spots to wipe and dry:** front-loading washer door gaskets, refrigerator drip pans, under sinks, shower corners, and window tracks.

## Small spots of mold

**THE SIMPLE VERSION**

**If you see a little mold, tell a grown-up.**
**Kids and people with allergies should stay away while it gets cleaned.**

- **Fix the water first, then clean.** For small areas on hard surfaces, scrub with water and detergent and dry completely.[6]
- **Removing beats killing.** Dead mold can still cause allergic reactions, so it must be removed. EPA does not recommend bleach or other biocides as a routine part of mold cleanup.[7] Never mix bleach with ammonia or other cleaners.[8]
- **Who should not clean mold:** people with allergies, asthma, COPD, other lung disease, or weakened immune systems. Anyone cleaning should wear at least an N95 respirator, gloves, and goggles without vent holes.[9]
- **Porous materials may need to go.** Moldy carpet, ceiling tiles, and similar absorbent materials often cannot be fully cleaned.[7] If growth covers more than about 10 square feet (roughly 3 ft by 3 ft), or there was a lot of water damage, get professional help.[7]
- **Avoid fogging or spraying** products as a substitute for cleaning, and skip heavily scented cleaners and air fresheners.

**Your next step**

Switch to damp dusting and a sealed HEPA vacuum this week. If mold growth is larger than about 10 square feet or keeps coming back, contact us before cleaning.

## Sources for this part

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